

How a country scan works

National uptake of Recommendation Rec(2022)2

Method note for country experts and review partners

Version for the Belgium proof of concept — 28 September 2026

One-sentence summary

A country scan is a checklist-driven desk review of public legal sources against Rec(2022)2's 58 duties, with every search and judgement written into the repository so an expert can reproduce, challenge, or correct it. It is not a black-box score.

1. What we are checking against

Before any country is opened, the project already has a codebook (`codebook/codebook.md`). That is the checklist. It was built from Recommendation Rec(2022)2:

Part of the recommendation	What it covers in the review
Annex 1	National law topics: governance, venue safety, certification, infrastructure, emergency planning, access/tickets, policing, bans, dialogue, offences
Annex 2	Stewarding topics: status, qualification, vetting, duties, powers, conduct, visibility, records, training, private-security link

That gives 16 topic groups (clusters) and 58 individual duties (indicators).

Examples of duties:

- Is there a named national coordinating body?
- Is a safety officer required at the venue?
- Is CCTV required at designated venues?
- Can stewards search at entry?
- Is there a national football information point?
- Must stewards complete approved training before deployment?

Every country is scored against the same 58. We do not invent new questions per country.

2. What “doing a country” involves, step by step

Step A — Confirm party status

Look up whether the country is a State Party to the Saint-Denis Convention (CETS No. 218), with signature, ratification, and entry-into-force dates.

Belgium example: signed 29 November 2016; ratified 9 September 2024; in force 1 November 2024 (Council of Europe country profile + BeSafe ratification notice).

Step B — Run the fixed search protocol

The project README fixes six source families that must be checked for every country:

1. National legislation database or official gazette
2. Ministry responsible for sport, and the authority responsible for policing sports events
3. Stadium licensing or safety-certification authority
4. National football association's safety and stadium rules
5. National football information point (NFIP), or the body that carries that function
6. Direct search for Rec (2022) 2 , the Saint-Denis Convention, and CETS No. 218

Searches use the indicator wording and national-language legal terms (for Belgium: loi football, stewards, interdiction de stade, responsable de la sécurité, and so on).

Empty results are logged as carefully as hits. A search that finds nothing is still part of the audit trail.

Step C — Open the actual instruments

Titles alone are not enough. The reviewer opens statutes, royal decrees / regulations, consolidated texts, and official ministry pages, and reads the provisions that speak to each duty.

Belgium example — main instruments opened:

- Loi du 21 décembre 1998 (consolidated Football Act)
- Loi du 19 juin 2023 (amending Act)
- Arrêté royal du 25 mai 1999 (steward engagement)
- Arrêté royal du 15 juin 1999 (coordination / safety officer / Cellule football)
- Arrêté royal du 6 juillet 2013 (stadium safety norms)
- CCTV, ticketing, and stadium-ban file decrees
- BeSafe policy pages; CoE country profile; NFIP descriptions

What was not opened is also stated (for Belgium: full RBFA/Pro League licensing books end to end; every OOP circular; non-football sports instruments).

Step D — Map text to each of the 58 duties

For each duty, the reviewer asks: does a national instrument require this?

Judgement	Meaning
met	A national instrument requires the substance of the duty for football matches or other sports events in scope
partial	Only part of the duty; only some events; or guidance / practice rather than a hard requirement
not_found	The search protocol was completed and no such instrument was identified
not_applicable	The duty cannot apply; the assessment says why

Also recorded for every duty:

- Confidence — high / medium / low
- Change since 1 September 2022 — new / amended / unchanged / unknown
- Evidence — which instruments support the line

Belgium example: “safety officer” → Football Act art. 6 + AR 15 June 1999 → `met` , high confidence, unchanged since 2022.

Statute, regulation, and a licensing condition that a venue must meet can all count as `met` . A football-association rule or ministry circular can be `met` when it is the instrument that actually imposes the duty. A strategy or guidance note that only recommends the duty is `partial` .

Step E — Write two files

File	Audience	Purpose
<code>countries/<country>.md</code>	Humans (review team + country expert)	Readable brief: short answer, changes since 2022, topic narrative, judgement table, survey questions, sources
<code>countries/<country>.yaml</code>	Working record / later comparison	Structured searches, evidence list, all 58 judgements with evidence IDs and notes

Step F — Generate survey questions

Anything judged `partial` , `not_found` , or low-confidence becomes a pre-filled question for the country expert:

We found X. It appears to meet / partially meet / not address this duty. Please confirm, correct, or name the instrument that should replace this finding.

One open question also asks what has changed since 1 September 2022 that the brief missed. Replies use the same indicator IDs so they can update the assessment and be compared across countries.

3. How you know which pages were gone through

Nothing is invisible. There are three audit layers in every country file.

A. Search log (`searches:` in the `.yaml`)

Each check records:

- source family (gazette / police / licensing / sport ministry / football association / NFIP / citation)
- query used
- date
- outcome (`hit` or `none`)
- URL
- note

B. “Where this was looked for” table (in the `.md`)

A plain table: place → what was opened → result.
It also states what was not opened in that pass.

C. Evidence list + per-indicator sources

Each instrument gets an evidence entry (title, citation, URL, date, language, short paraphrase).
Each of the 58 judgements points back to those evidence IDs.
The judgement table at the end of the `.md` has a one-line source per duty.
Full URLs are repeated under Sources.

So if a partner asks “did you actually look at the steward decree?”, the answer is in the yaml search entry, the evidence ID, the md search table, and every indicator that cites that decree.

4. What this is not

Important for expectations:

- Not a live scrape of every law in the country’s database. It is targeted search plus reading of opened pages and PDFs.
- Not a model that “knows” national law. The review only knows what it found and cited in that pass.
- Not exhaustive of every circular or association handbook. If something was not opened, the brief says so and drops confidence or marks `partial` / a survey question.
- Association practice is not automatically statute. Club web pages can support `partial` ; they do not get treated as a hard national duty unless a binding instrument requires it.
- Language limits are recorded. A judgement on a text the reviewer could not fully verify stays at lower confidence until a reader of that language, or the country representative, confirms it.
- Expert validation is part of the design. The desk review is the draft map. The survey is how the country expert closes gaps.

5. What has been completed so far

Country	Role	File
United Kingdom	First completed review	<code>countries/united-kingdom.md</code>
Austria	Second review (German-language instruments)	<code>countries/austria.md</code>
Belgium	Third review / proof of concept for expert feedback	<code>countries/belgium.md</code>

Belgium was chosen as a PoC because it has a dedicated federal Football Act and a dedicated stewarding royal decree — a strong comparator for how far Rec(2022)2’s model already appears in national law for football.

6. What a partner should open first

File	What it is
codebook/codebook.md	The 58 duties being checked
README.md	Method, judgement rules, search protocol
countries/belgium.md	Readable Belgium findings + search table + survey questions
countries/belgium.yaml	Full audit trail: searches, evidence, all 58 lines
This note	Process explanation for partners

Belgium PoC pull request: <https://github.com/ds10/council-of-euro-recommendation-2022/pull/6>

7. End-to-end flow (for a single country)

```
Rec(2022)2 Annex 1 + Annex 2
  ↓
Codebook (58 duties)
  ↓
Fixed search protocol (6 source families)
  ↓
Open and read national instruments
  ↓
Judgement per duty: status + confidence + change + source
  ↓
Country brief (.md) + working record (.yaml)
  ↓
Survey questions for country expert
  ↓
Expert confirms / corrects / supplies missing instruments
  ↓
Assessment updated → later cross-country map
```

Prepared for Micheal's team from the Rec(2022)2 national uptake review repository. Desk reviews stay in the repository; country-representative contact details do not.